

VEDIC CULTURE

By 1800 BCE, the Harappan civilization had declined, paving the way for the Vedic Civilization (1500–600 BCE), which evolved through the Rigvedic (1500–1000 BCE) and Later Vedic (1000–600 BCE) periods. Marked by the composition of the Vedas, this era shaped Indian culture, religion, and societal structures. The Rigvedic people, initially settling in the Punjab region, practiced a pastoral lifestyle and worshipped nature-based deities. Over time, during the Later Vedic period, they expanded into the Indo-Gangetic plains, leading to socio-political changes, emergence of kingdoms, and a shift towards agrarian economy and organized rituals.

The word 'Veda' comes from the Sanskrit root '**vid,**' meaning '**to know.**' Primarily comprising prayers and hymns to deities, the Vedas are religious and ritualistic rather than historical records. Originally preserved through oral transmission, they were memorized and recited rather than written down, leading to two key implications:

1. **Dating Uncertainty:** Compiled centuries after their composition, likely for ritual codification, the exact dates of the Vedas remain uncertain.
2. **Limited Representation:** Strict memorization ensured their preservation but restricted access to a select priestly class, particularly Brahmanas, making them unreflective of broader societal beliefs and practices.

The Vedas are neither historical records nor popular literature, yet they offer insights into the past. Their geographical references and underlying social assumptions provide valuable historical perspectives.

Sources

Literary Sources

The primary source of information about the Aryans is derived from the Vedic texts, which offer valuable insights into their society, culture, and

beliefs. Based on these texts, the Vedic period is typically divided into two phases: the Early Vedic period (1500-1000 BCE) and the Later Vedic period (1000-600 BCE, with some scholars extending it to 500 BCE). The early portions of the Rig Veda belong to the Early Vedic period, while the later additions, the remaining three Vedas, and related texts (Brahmanas, Aranyakas, and Upanishads) belong to the Later Vedic period.

Shruti and Smriti Literature:

Vedic texts are categorized as **Shruti** ("that which is heard") because they are believed to be divinely revealed to sages, while **Smriti** ("that which is remembered") refers to post-Vedic texts based on human recollection. Smriti texts are considered less authoritative and exist in various versions. Examples of Smriti literature include the **Vedangas**, **Puranas**, **Epics**, **Dharamashastras**, and **Nitishastras**.

THE VEDIC CORPUS (SHRUTI LITERATURE)

- **Rigveda**

The Rigveda is the oldest Veda, comprising ten books (mandalas). It includes important hymns like Vishvamitra's Gayatri mantra and the Purusha Shukta, which narrates the story of the Primal Man. The Rigvedic priest, called the Hotri, played a central role in rituals. Books 1, 8, 9, and 10 are later additions, and the Sakala recension is the only surviving version.

- **Samaveda**

The Samaveda, the shortest Veda, consists of Rigvedic verses rearranged for chanting during rituals. It is meant for the Udgatar priest and marks the origin of Indian music. Surviving recensions include Kauthuma, Ranayaniya, and Jaiminiya, with Brahmanas like Tandya and Jaiminiya, and Upanishads like Chandogya and Kena.

- **Yajurveda**

The Yajurveda, a manual for the Adhvaryu priest, is divided into "black" (Krishna) and "white" (Shukla) sections. It provides hymns and rituals for sacrifices, with key Brahmanas like the Shatapatha Brahmana.

- **Atharvaveda**

The Atharvaveda focuses on spells for healing, protection, and warding off evil spirits. It reflects folk traditions and includes recensions like Shaunaka and Paippalada, with Brahmanas such as Gopatha. Upanishads like Mundaka, Mandukya, and Prashna are also part of this Veda.

Vedic Structure

Each Veda consists of four parts:

- **Samhitas**: Early mantras, hymns, and prayers dedicated to deities.
- **Brahmanas**: Prose commentaries explaining rituals' socio-religious significance.
- **Aranyakas**: Philosophical reinterpretations of rituals by forest-dwelling sages.
- **Upanishads**: Philosophical texts exploring concepts of Atman (soul) and Brahman (universal spirit). They emphasize the realization of Brahman as the path to liberation (moksha).

The Upanishads, while not rejecting sacrifice, redefine it by focusing on the symbolic knowledge behind rituals. Advaita Vedanta, a key interpretation by Adi Shankara, became highly influential.

POST-VEDIC CORPUS (SMRITI LITERATURE)

The Epics (Ramayana and Mahabharata)

The *Ramayana* and *Mahabharata* are key epics in early Indian literature, emerging in the post-Vedic period, offering insights into society rather than being historical accounts. The term *itihasa* ("thus it was") reflects their role in shaping historical perceptions, though their accuracy is debated.

- **Mahabharata**

One of the longest epics, the *Mahabharata* consists of around 100,000 verses and is sometimes called the "fifth Veda." Initially composed orally by bards, it was later written down by Brahmins

around the 5th century BCE. The epic is centered on the Kauravas and Pandavas, two branches of the Kuru clan, and features key teachings like the Bhagavad Gita. Although the battle is thought to have occurred around 1000 BCE, its historical accuracy remains uncertain.

- **Ramayana**

The *Ramayana*, with 24,000 verses, is shorter than the *Mahabharata* and is attributed to Maharishi Valmiki. It tells the story of Rama, his exile, Sita's abduction by Ravana, and Rama's rescue mission with the help of Hanuman. The epic highlights idealized governance through Rama's reign. Its influence spread across India and beyond, adapting into various regional versions.

Puranas

The *Puranas* are religious texts that began as oral traditions and were compiled around 200 CE onwards. They describe the universe's creation and destruction, the genealogies of kings, sages, and deities, and offer their version of the genesis of Indian civilization. While generally composed in simple Sanskrit, they were meant to be accessible to all, including women and Shudras, who were excluded from Vedic knowledge. The *Puranas* served as vehicles for Brahmanical social and religious values.

Vyasa, the compiler of the *Mahabharata*, is traditionally credited with the compilation of the *Puranas*. Among the 18 *Mahapuranas* that are considered the most important, several are named after major deities like Brahma, Vishnu, Shiva, and Agni. The *Puranas* are said to have five characteristics (*pancha-lakshanas*) and cover five key topics:

- *Sarga*: The creation of the universe
- *Pratisarga*: The re-creation of the universe
- *Manvantara*: The periods of various Manus (progenitors of human beings)

Dharmasutras and Dharmashastras

The *Dharmasutras* are texts that deal with rituals, rules, laws, and

duties, covering topics like marriage, property laws, and the duties of various social classes (varnas) and rulers. These were later expanded into more comprehensive *Dharmashastras*.

The *Dharmashastras* were composed in poetic verses and discuss the conduct of individuals within society to fulfill the four goals of human life (*purusharthas*): Dharma (righteous conduct), Artha (material prosperity), Kama (sensual pleasure), and Moksha (liberation). They focus on the duties and ethics associated with each varna and the four stages of life (ashramas).

The *Manusmriti*, compiled between 200 BCE and 200 CE, is the most important of the *Dharmashastras* and offers a social code that historians use to infer societal norms during the time of its composition.

Upavedas

The *Upavedas* are four texts regarded as supplementary to the Vedas, each dealing with a specific category of knowledge:

- *Ayurveda* (medicine) – associated with the *Atharvaveda*
- *Dhanurveda* (archery) – associated with the *Yajurveda*
- *Gandharvaveda* (music and dance) – associated with the *Samaveda*
- *Sthapatyaveda* (architecture) – associated with the *Rigveda*

These texts mark the beginning of specialized knowledge in various fields like medicine, warfare, and arts.

Archaeological Sources

There is no definitive archaeological evidence confirming the arrival of Aryans in India. However, inscriptions from **West Asia** suggest their presence:

- **Hittite Inscription (c. 1900 BCE, Turkey)** – One of the earliest references to Indo-European groups in Anatolia.
- **Kassite Inscription (c. 1600 BCE, Iraq)** – Contains **Aryan names resembling Sanskrit**, indicating early Indo-Aryan presence.

- **Mitanni Inscription (c. 1400 BCE, Syria)** – Records a **treaty between a Hittite and a Mitanni king**, invoking Rigvedic deities.
- **Boğazköy Inscription (c. 1400 BCE, Turkey)** – Specifically mentions **Indra, Mitra, Varuna, and Nasatya**, marking the earliest **Rig Vedic** references outside India.

Excavations over the past **40 years** along the **Indus and Ghaggar rivers** in Punjab, Uttar Pradesh, and northern Rajasthan have revealed **post-Harappan/Chalcolithic settlements**, including Late Harappan, **Ochre-Coloured Pottery (OCP)**, **Black and Red Ware (BRW)**, and **Painted Grey Ware (PGW) cultures**. Scholars correlate these findings with **Vedic texts**.

PGW Culture and Later Vedic Period

The **Later Vedic texts (c.1000–500 BCE)** were compiled in the **upper and middle Ganga basin**, coinciding with the **Painted Grey Ware (PGW) culture**, which represents a **proto-urban phase** characterized by **agriculture and iron use**. **Carbon-14 dating** suggests iron was introduced around **1000–800 BCE**, corroborated by literary references in the **Yajur Veda ('Shyama ayas')** and the **Brahmanas ('Krishna ayas')**, both referring to black metal (iron). PGW settlements were **new, without predecessors**, marking a transition to a **settled agricultural society**. Due to cultural similarities, some scholars equate **PGW people with later Vedic people**, making the study of PGW crucial for understanding **their material conditions**.

PGW Sites

More than **700 PGW sites** have been discovered in the **upper Ganga basin**, spanning:

- **Ghaggar (Bahawalpur, Rajasthan)** → Ganga-Yamuna doab
- **Kuru-Panchala (Western UP, Delhi)**
- **Madra (Punjab, Haryana)**
- **Matsya (Rajasthan)**

Notable PGW sites:

- **Rupar (Punjab)**
- **Bhagwanpura, Kurukshetra (Haryana)**
- **Jodhpura, Noh (Rajasthan)**
- **Ahichchhatra, Hastinapur, Atranjikhhera, Jakhera, Mathura (UP)**

Iron objects are found at all PGW sites **except Hastinapur**.

EARLY VEDIC PERIOD

Who Were the Vedic Aryans? How Did the Aryans Migrate to India?

The Vedic Aryans were the composers of the Vedic hymns. In the 19th century, Aryans were considered a race, but they are now identified as a **linguistic group** speaking Indo-European languages. Originally from the Steppes, spanning southern Russia to Central Asia, a group migrated to northwest India, becoming known as **Indo-Aryans**. Historians and archaeologists distinguish them from the non-Aryan Harappans of the preceding era.

Attempts have been made to link post-Harappan cultures to the Aryans, with the Painted Grey Ware often associated with their craftsmanship. Archaeological evidence of Aryan migration traces back to the Andronovo Culture in southern Siberia, which flourished in the second millennium BCE. From there, they moved north of the Hindukush before entering India. The newcomers arrived in multiple waves, leading to the predominance of the Vedic form of the Aryan language across northwestern India. The texts composed in this language are known as the Vedic Texts.

Debate Regarding Original Homes of The Aryans

Max Müller: A 19th-century philologist who was instrumental in the development of the **Central Asia theory**. He focused on the similarities between Sanskrit and European languages.

Sir William Jones: Another early linguist who noted the connections

between Sanskrit, Greek, and Latin, laying the groundwork for the Indo-European language family concept.

Dayananda Saraswati: A 19th-century Indian philosopher and social reformer who argued that the Aryans were indigenous to India and that the Vedas originated there.

B.G. Tilak: An Indian nationalist leader and scholar who supported the indigenous origin theory, drawing on interpretations of Vedic texts.

A.C. Das: An Indian historian who argued against the Central Asian theory and proposed that the Aryans were originally from the Sapta Sindh region (the land of seven rivers in northwest India).

Geographical Spread



The Rigveda mentions four Afghan rivers—**Kubha (Kabul)**, **Krumu (Kurram)**, **Gomti (Gomal)**, and **Suvastu (Swat)**—and refers to the Sapt-Saindhav region, encompassing **Sindhu (Indus)**, **Shatudri (Satluj)**, **Vitasta (Jhelum)**, **Askini (Chenab)**, **Parushni (Ravi)**, **Vipasa (Beas)**, and **Sarasvati**. The Indus is the most frequently mentioned river, while Sarasvati is praised as **Naditama**, the best among rivers.

Some identify Sarasvati with the Ghaggar-Hakra, while others link it to the Avestan Haraxvati (Helmand) in Afghanistan.

The Aryans initially settled in Punjab and Afghanistan before moving eastward to Kurukshetra, known as **Brahmavarta**. The Rigveda briefly mentions the Ganga and Yamuna, indicating awareness of these rivers but placing them at the eastern boundary of their geography. It also references the Kashmiri river **Marudvridha** and the Himalayan peak **Mujavant**, known for the soma plant. Thus, the Rigvedic Aryans inhabited a region spanning Afghanistan to the western Ganga and from the Himalayas to northern Rajasthan.

Aryan Conflicts and Tribal Struggles

The Aryans arrived in waves, often clashing with indigenous inhabitants and among themselves over cattle raids and pastureland. The Rigveda calls Indra **Purandara** (breaker of forts), but the owners of these forts remain unknown.

Aryan and Non-Aryan Tribes

The Aryans were divided into five main tribes, the **Panch-Jana—Anu, Yadu, Druhyu, Turvasha, and Bharatas**. The ruling clans were the Bharatas and Tritsus, with India later named **Bharatvarsha** after the Bharatas. Indigenous people were termed **Dasas and Dasyus**, though some believe they were an early Aryan branch. The Rigveda mentions the Puru chief **Transdasyu** and the defeat of Shambara by Bharata king **Divodasa**.

Battle of Ten Kings (Dashrajan Yuddha)

The Bharatas, led by King Sudas, fought a confederacy of ten tribes (five Aryan and five non-Aryan) on the banks of the Ravi (Parushni). Sudas, advised by *purohit* Vashishtha (who replaced Vishwamitra), emerged victorious and performed the **Ashwamedha** sacrifice. Later, the Bharatas allied with the defeated Purus, forming the Kuru tribe.

Note: In the later Vedic period, the Kurus expanded eastward, occupying the upper Doab (modern Delhi), which became *Kurukshetra*. They later

allied with the Panchalas of the middle Doab, strengthening their dominance.

Economy

The Rig Vedic period, spanning from approximately 1500 to 1000 BCE, had an economy that was primarily **pastoral and agrarian**, with a gradual shift towards agriculture. Here's a breakdown of the key aspects:

Pastoralism:

- **Cattle rearing:** Cattle, especially cows (**gau**), were central to the Rig Vedic economy. They were not only a source of milk, ghee, and other dairy products but also a measure of wealth. The term "**Go-dhana**" literally means "wealth of cows." Cattle were so important that they were often the cause of conflicts and raids between tribes; the term for battle used in Rigveda is **gavishti** meaning search for cows.
- **Nomadic lifestyle:** The early Rig Vedic people were semi-nomadic, moving in search of pastures for their cattle. This limited the scope for large-scale, settled agriculture. Gifts to priests generally consisted of cows and women slaves, but never of land. The concept of private ownership of land had not yet evolved.
- **Horses:** The horses are also important. It is believed that the Aryans succeeded in India and won battles against the indigenous people thanks to their horses and chariots. The Aryans also introduced the chariot with a spoked wheel for the first time.

Rigvedic Terms	Meanings
Gopati	one who protects the cow; refers to raja or chief.
Gomat	owner of cattle; refers to a wealthy man. Thus, cattle was the chief measure of wealth.
Gotra	kinship unit.
Duhitr	she who milks the cow; refers to daughter.
Godhuli	a measure of time, dusk.
Samgava	morning.
Gavyuti, gocharman	measure of area/distance.
Gavishti, gavsena, gavyat	terms used for conflicts and battles—indicating that many battles were in effect cattle raids.
Gojit	winner of cows; refers to a hero.

Agriculture:

- **Gradual shift:** As the Rig Vedic people settled in the fertile plains of the Sapta Sindhu region (the land of seven rivers), they gradually shifted towards agriculture. Some scholars believed that agriculture was only subsidiary and chiefly done to produce fodder.
- **Crops: Barley (yava)** was the main crop, followed by **wheat (godhuma)**. Other crops included pulses, legumes, and possibly rice in some areas.
- **Farming practices:** They used wooden **ploughs (langala and sura)** and likely had some knowledge of irrigation, though not as advanced as in later periods. The Rigveda contains numerous references to agriculture, using verbs like **vap (to sow)** and **krish (to cultivate)**.

Rigvedic Terms	Meanings
Yava	Barley
Dhanya	Cereals
Vap	To sow
krish	To cultivate
phala, langala	Plough
Khanitra	Hoe
Srini	Sickle
parashu, kulisha	Axe
Kshetra	Cultivated field
Urvara	Fertile fields
Sita	Furrows
Urvarajit	Winner of fertile fields; refers to god Indra.
Kshetrapati	Guardian deity of agricultural fields; this god is invoked in later parts of the family books, when wars were fought for land in addition to cattle.

Craft and technology:

- **Skilled artisans:** The Rig Vedic people had skilled artisans who practiced various crafts like carpentry, weaving, pottery, and metalworking.
- **Carpentry:** Carpenters were highly esteemed for crafting chariots, vital for transportation and warfare. Chariot-makers held a special status, and carpentry flourished due to the abundant wood from cleared forests.

- **Metalworking:** The term *ayas* in the Rigveda refers to metals, indicating knowledge of metalworking. The Rigvedic people were familiar with copper and bronze (*ayas*), using them for tools, weapons, and ornaments. However, iron was not yet widely used.

Trade and commerce:

- Trade was limited, relying on barter with cattle as a key unit of value. Large transactions used **gold pieces (*nishka*)**, though coins were absent. There is no clear evidence of foreign or sea trade, and *samudra* in the Rigveda likely referred to a large body of water.

Gift-Giving:

- Gift-giving played a key role in wealth redistribution. The tribal chief received **voluntary offerings (*bali*)**, mainly agricultural produce and cattle, and a share of **war booty (*bhaga*)**. Over time, these terms evolved into tax-related concepts.
- **Bards** composing eulogies for chiefs were rewarded with ***dana*** (gifts), leading to ***dana-stuti*** hymns praising generosity. This practice later developed into ***dakshina***—a fee given by patrons to priests for performing sacrifices, solidifying the patron-priest relationship.
- Archaeological finds, such as a 13-room mud-brick house at Bhagwanpura, Haryana, provide insights into Rigvedic material culture, revealing cattle and horse bones, possibly linked to this period.

Polity

The polity was tribal but not completely egalitarian. It had a strong military aspect but lacked territorial administration, as the migrating Aryans were in an expansion phase.

Tribal Chief

The **rajan** (tribal chief) served as the leader, responsible for protecting his people and leading in war. He was also called **gopa** or **gopati** (lord of cattle), highlighting his role in safeguarding livestock. His power was

not absolute and was regulated by tribal assemblies. Initially, the **samiti** (assembly) elected him, but over time, the position became hereditary. A full-fledged monarchical state had not yet emerged.

Tribal Assemblies

The Rigveda mentions several tribal assemblies, including **sabha**, **samiti**, **vidatha**, and **gana**. The **sabha** was a smaller, select body, while the **samiti** was a larger assembly. Tribal administration was conducted in consultation with these bodies. Women could participate in the **sabha** and **vidatha**.

- **Sabha** – An aristocratic assembly of elders and nobles that advised the king and handled judicial matters.
- **Samiti** – A democratic assembly of the people responsible for electing the king and discussing political affairs.
- **Vidatha** – A socio-religious gathering involved in rituals, charity, warfare, and economic activities, with women's participation.
- **Gana** – A tribal organization or oligarchic system where multiple chiefs collectively ruled.

Other Functionaries

Besides the rajan, some other functionaries in his day-to-day activities included:

- **Purohita (priest)** – The most important functionary, performing sacrifices on behalf of the chief and the tribe. The most famous purohita was **Vashishtha**, who composed many hymns of the Rigveda. Another important priest was **Vishvamitra**, who was also a warrior and composed the **Gayatri Mantra**.
- **Senani (military commander)** – He played an important role in battles and conflicts.
- **Gramani (leader of the village)** – This position later became hereditary.
- **Sangrahitri** – A revenue collector who may have been connected with redistribution of justice or with the collection of taxes.
- **Spies** were employed to keep an eye over anti-social activities like cow thefts.

- The Rigveda does not mention any officer concerned with administration of justice or with collection of taxes- indicating that a regular taxation system had not emerged yet. But Rajan received voluntary offerings (gifts/tribute) from the people called **Bali**.

Warriors and Priests

The **rajan's** close kinsmen formed the warrior class, known as **rajanya**, distinct from the common clansmen or **vish**. The **rajan** did not have a standing army but assembled militia groups like **vrata**, **gana**, **grama**, and **sardha** during warfare.

Large **yagyas** (sacrifices) were conducted to support warriors in battle, with the **purohita** (priest) serving as a mediator between the clan and the gods. As conflicts increased, warriors and priests gained prominence, eventually evolving into distinct **Kshatriya** and **Brahmana** varnas in the later Vedic period.

Note: The **Rigveda** mentions the **Brahmanas** as one among seven priestly groups. Over time, these groups expanded to sixteen, but the **Brahmanas** gained dominance, becoming the most influential priestly class. This rise in their status was unique to Indian Aryan society and was not observed in other Aryan communities.

Socio-Political Units

The polity was structured into **kinship-based socio-political units**: **kula (family)**, led by the **kulapa**; multiple families formed a **grama**, headed by the **gramani**; several gramas made up a **vish (clan)**, overseen by the **vishapati**; and the largest unit, the **jana (tribe)**, was ruled by the **rajan**. The term **grama** also referred to a small tribal fighting unit, and conflicts between them led to **samgrama (war)**.

Note: According to R.S. Sharma, the **gramani's role evolved over time**. Initially, he led a **tribal fighting unit**, but as settlements developed, he became the **head of a village**. Later, he assumed the role of **vrajapati**, overseeing a larger territory and leading **kulapas and gramanis** in battle.

Society

The Rigvedic society was tribal and largely egalitarian, with social bonds rooted in clan and kinship ties. The primary socio-political units followed a hierarchy: **Kula** → **Grama** → **Vish** → **Jana**. The term *jana* appears frequently in the Rigveda, indicating a tribal, non-territorial society.

Social Structure

The family (*griha*) was patriarchal and joint, led by the eldest male (*grihapati*). Settlements formed villages (*grama*), which combined into clans (*vish*), eventually forming tribes (*jana*). The most populous varna, *Vaishya*, likely emerged from the *vish*.

Gender and Marriage

Society was **patriarchal and patrilineal**, with a preference for sons. Monogamy was the norm, though polygamy and polyandry existed among elites. Women had some agency in choosing partners, and practices like **widow remarriage and *niyoga* (levirate)** were accepted. *Sati* was absent. Some women, like Ghosha and Lopamudra, composed hymns, though their access to sacred learning was limited.

Daily Life

People consumed **wheat, barley, fruits, vegetables, milk, and dairy products**, with occasional meat consumption. The cow was sacred (*aghanya*). Soma (ritual intoxicant) and Sura (grain liquor) were popular beverages. Clothing was made from **cotton, wool, and animal skins**, and both genders wore ornaments. Leisure activities included **horse racing, music, gambling, and dice games**.

Social Stratification

Although social divisions existed, they were fluid. The **varna system** was emerging but not rigid. The **Purusha Sukta** (considered a later addition) introduced a fourfold division:

- **Brahmana** (priests)
- **Kshatriya** (warriors)
- **Vaishya** (commoners)
- **Shudra** (subjugated groups)

Initially, society had only three classes (*Brahmana*, *Kshatriya*, *Rajanya*), with *Shudras* appearing later as the Aryans subjugated indigenous tribes (*Dasas*, *Dasyus*). The term *varna* originally meant “color,” associating social hierarchy with skin tone. Interestingly, **social mobility was still possible**. The Rigveda records a family where one member states:

"I am a poet, my father is a physician, and my mother grinds grain."

Economic Disparity

Wealth was measured in **cattle, chariots, and war booty**, with chiefs and priests receiving the largest shares. However, the economy was primarily **pastoral**, with no structured taxation system.

Despite emerging inequalities, Rigvedic society remained more flexible than later Vedic periods, allowing for some **social mobility** and women's participation in religious and intellectual spheres.

Religion

The hymns of the **Rigveda** reflect the religious ideas of its people, showing similarities with the **Iranian Avesta**. The universe was divided into **the sky, the earth, and the intermediate space (antariksha)**. Deities were called **deva**, while **asura**, initially meaning powerful beings, later came to denote demons. Creation theories included **cosmic sacrifice, divine battle, or godly actions**.

Gods and Worship

Rigvedic people practiced **naturalistic polytheism**, worshipping natural forces like rain, fire, and wind, personified as mostly male deities. Indra, Agni, and Soma were key gods, though some scholars argue that any invoked deity was regarded as supreme, a concept called **henotheism** by **Max Müller**. Unlike the Harappans, **Rigvedic goddesses held little significance**, with no major deity personified as female.

Rigvedic Gods	Description
Indra	He was the god of rain, storm, and thunder; was the most important God (250 hundred hymns are devoted to him). Since rain and thunder were related with strength, he was also the god of strength who was invoked to destroy the enemies; he was called purandar or breaker of forts; he was the warlord who led Aryan soldiers to victory against the demons. He was the bounteous one (maghavan) and Vritrahan (slayer of serpent demon Vritra). Indrani was his consort, the Maruts his companions and he loved to drink soma.

Agni	The second position in terms of importance was held by Agni, the god of fire (200 hymns). He represented many aspects of fire—but most important of all, as the sacrificial fire. He was considered as intermediary between heaven and earth, or gods and men—thus seen in the role of a divine priest. The offerings to Agni were supposed to be carried in the form of smoke to the sky, and thus reached the gods. He also dominated the domestic hearth; marriages were solemnized in his presence; the dead were consecrated to the funeral pyre. Fire destroyed dirt and germs and was thought to be the purest of the five elements.
Varuna	The third position was held by Varuna, the god of water. He was the upholder of rita, i.e., the natural order of the universe, as well as the moral order that humans must follow. All events in the world were believed to be a reflection of his desires. He is associated with maya and the ability to see all. He punishes the evil-doers with the fetters at his command.
Mitra	Varuna and Mitra are frequently invoked together; they are both members of an eight-member group of gods known as the Adityas (Varuna, Mitra, Surya, Soma, Kamdeva, Agni, Indra). Adityas means 'of Aditi', i.e., sons of goddess Aditi and sage Kashyapa. The eighth Aditya Martanda was rejected by Aditi.
Soma	Soma was the personification of the soma plant (possibly ephedra or fly agaric mushroom) from which an intoxicating drink 'soma' was prepared; it is described as a divine drink that conferred immortality. Soma god was the wise one who inspired poets to compose hymns. In the later Vedic texts, he is referred to as the king of the brahmanas. An entire book of the Rigveda (book 9) is dedicated to soma.
Surya	Surya, the son of Dyaus, was the sun god. He is visualized as riding his chariot across the sky, sometimes also as a white horse or an eagle. He drove away darkness and brought light.
Vayu	Vayu was the wind god.
Ashvins	The Ashvins are twin gods associated with war and fertility.
Vishnu	The Rigveda also mentions Vishnu, but infrequently. A reference is made of his three gigantic strides that encompassed the entire universe.
Rudra	Similarly, Rudra (similar to later day Puranic Shiva) is also mentioned infrequently. Rudra inspired fear and is associated with destructive potential.
Pushan	Pushan was the god of cattle and herbs. He was responsible for roads, journeys, and marriages. His mount was the chariot pulled by goats.
Yama	Yama was the god of death.

Rigvedic Goddesses	
Aditi	We also find female deities such as Aditi, mother of the Adityas. Her name means freedom and she is invoked for freedom from sickness, harm, evil.
Ushas	Ushas is the goddess of dawn , she is the generous one invoked by seekers of wealth.
Raka	The benevolent, bountiful goddess.
Sinivali	Bestows children.
Prithvi	The earth goddess.
Vach	Speech.

Purpose and Methods of Worship

Worship aimed at **material gains** such as **children, cattle, wealth, health, and victory in battles**, rather than spiritual growth. There were **no temples or idol worship**; rituals involved **prayers and sacrifices (yajnas)** performed at home. Offerings like **milk, ghee, and grain** were poured into the fire, sometimes including **animal sacrifice**.

Sacrifices were conducted by householders or ritual specialists, with the **Rigveda mentioning seven types of priests: Brahman, Hotri, Potri, Neshtri, Adhvaryu, Agnidh, and Maitravaruna**. The concept of **cosmic sacrifice** was central, and rituals contributed to advancements in **mathematics, astronomy, and timekeeping**.

Pastoral Influence on Religion

The sacrificial system reflected **pastoral life**, where older, non-productive animals were sacrificed to reduce economic burden. In contrast, agrarian societies found utility for aging animals, making such sacrifices less desirable. Thus, early Vedic religion was deeply **patriarchal and materialistic**, shaped by the **pastoral lifestyle** of its followers.

Funerary Practices

The Rigveda mentions both cremation and burial. It also mentions **asu (a vital force)** and **manas (spirit)** that survive death. The ideas of hell and heaven also occur that are elaborated in later Vedic texts.

LATER VEDIC PERIOD

Use of Iron Technology

Earlier it was believed that

- 1) It were Aryans who introduced iron technology
- 2) They used iron axes to clear the dense forests in the doab region and settled there for permanent cultivation
- 3) The use of iron tipped ploughshares and hoes increased the efficiency of agricultural implements and furthered agricultural activities

But historians now generally agree that iron technology in the Indian subcontinent was indigenous, with excavations showing that the megalithic people of South India used iron. During the later Vedic period, society was not purely agrarian, and iron technology was still in its early stages. The rich iron ore mines of Bihar were largely untapped, and iron smelting remained primitive. The *Mahabharata* also mentions forest clearing by burning, supporting the idea that agriculture was not advanced at this time.

Iron was primarily used for weapons, as evidenced by archaeological findings of iron-tipped arrowheads and spearheads, while agricultural tools like ploughshares were rare. The *Mahabharata* depicts the use of iron weapons and chariots in military campaigns. Iron's influence on agriculture only grew in the second half of the first millennium BCE, when monsoon forests in the middle Ganga valley began to be cleared.

Geographical Spread

In the Later Vedic period, the Aryans had moved further eastward from the Sapta Sidhavah region into the Indo-Gangetic divide and upper and middle Ganga valley. Thus, the Aryans had expanded from Punjab over the whole of western Uttar Pradesh. Archaeological evidence reveals more than 700 sites that were inhabited in this region for the first time.

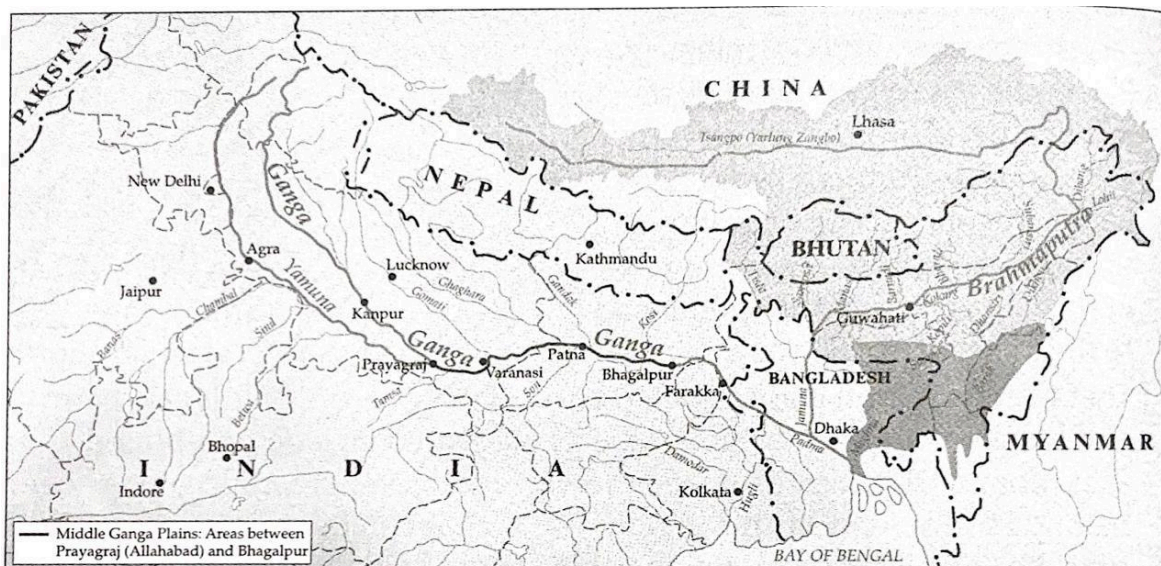
However, the geographical focus, i.e., the core geographical area to which the evidence of the later Vedic texts relates to is the Indo-Gangetic divide and upper Ganga valley (also known as **Kuru-Panchala region**, covering Delhi and western UP).

Shatapatha Brahmana: Story of Videgha Mathava
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The story of Videgha Mathava in the *Shatapatha Brahmana* is often interpreted as symbolizing the Aryan expansion eastward and their initial agricultural colonization by clearing forests through fire. Videgha, the founder of the Videha kingdom, followed a fire created by the god Agni, which spread eastward, burning everything in its path. However, the fire stopped at the Sadapira (Gandak river), marking the eastern boundary of the Aryans. The text also mentions the Reva (Narmada) and references eastern Himalayan mountains, indicating Aryan knowledge of the region by the later Vedic period.

During this phase, the Aryans moved east, occupying the Ganga-Yamuna Doab and surrounding areas, which they named **Brahmarishi Desha**. They later settled between the Himalayas and Vindhyachal, calling it **Madhya Desha**, and expanded into southeastern Bihar and Bengal. Over time, they influenced the entire northern Indian region, which they referred to as Aryavarta.

The Ganga Plains



Upper Ganga Plains: This region corresponds to western Uttar Pradesh and includes the Doab (the area between the Ganga and Yamuna rivers). It was the center of the PGW culture and saw significant activity during the Later Vedic Period.

Middle Ganga Plains: Moving eastward, the middle Ganga plains begin at Allahabad, where the Ganga and Yamuna converge. This area includes parts of eastern Uttar Pradesh and Bihar, particularly between Allahabad and Bhagalpur. It was a hub of activity in the 6th century BCE, with rice cultivation playing a crucial role in supporting the population.

Lower Ganga Plains: Further east, the lower plains extend into Bengal. Formed by the alluvium deposited by the Ganga and Brahmaputra rivers, this region saw urban culture spreading later from the middle plains. Fish became a significant part of the diet here.

The Ganga Plains have been central to Indian civilization from the first millennium BCE to the present. Compared to the Indus region, the Ganga basin is more humid, with annual rainfall increasing from 50 cm in the western part to 200 cm in Bengal, and it was likely more densely forested.

Economy

Agriculture

In the later Vedic period, agriculture flourished, aided by the fertile alluvial land of the Ganga-Yamuna Doab, with mixed farming emerging as the norm. Barley, rice, and wheat became key crops, with wheat being the staple in Punjab and western UP, while rice was introduced in the Doab. Though rice cultivation was still labor-intensive, it was not yet widespread. The Vedic texts emphasize rice in rituals, but wheat was mentioned less frequently. The growth of agriculture and sedentary life is evident in longer-lasting settlements and more durable housing materials. However, the use of primitive wooden ploughs and limited iron use hindered agricultural efficiency, preventing surplus production for city development. Thus, urbanism was not widespread, and towns like Hastinapur and Kaushambi remained primitive.

Pastoralism

While pastoralism continued, its significance declined in the later Vedic period, no longer being the primary subsistence activity.

Industry and Crafts

The later Vedic texts mention various artisans such as carpenters, chariot-makers, weavers, and metalworkers, indicating a growing industrial base. The Vedic people worked with copper, iron, and other metals. Pottery styles like red ware, black-slipped ware, and PGW emerged, with PGW being the most distinctive.

Trade and Commerce

The later Vedic people had some knowledge of sea voyages and inter-regional trade, though barter remained dominant. Gold pieces (nishka) served as a unit of value, but coinage began only in the 6th century BCE.

Transport

Oxen-pulled wagons were the primary mode of transport, with horses, elephants, and chariots also used for war and sport. Boats and sea voyages were also common.

Land Ownership

Land was primarily communally owned by the vish (clan), with no concept of private land ownership. Land was sometimes claimed by the Brahmanas as sacrificial fees, but the attitude toward land grants remained ambivalent. No reference to land sale or hired labor exists, and slaves were not employed in productive activities.

Redistribution and Social Changes

In the later Vedic phase, rituals became focused on consolidating power among the chiefs and Brahmanas, rather than benefiting the entire community. The material life advanced with the emergence of mixed farming, settled life, arts, crafts, and trade. However, limited agricultural surplus meant that while the chiefs and priests thrived, urban centers did not fully develop, keeping society largely rural.

Polity

The transition from pastoral to mixed farming economy significantly impacted the polity and society of later Vedic people. Tribal identities shifted to territorial ones, leading to changes in the roles of tribal chiefs

and more complex social relations. Allegiance was directed to territories rather than tribes, resulting in a more hierarchical society.

Rise of Janapadas (Territorial Entities)

By the 6th century BCE, the term *janapada* replaced **jana (tribe)**, signifying the territories where people settled. This period saw the rise of territorial states, marking the shift from tribal polities to more centralized systems, with monarchies and oligarchies emerging. While some communities retained tribal governance, others evolved into monarchies with power centralized in kings. States like Kuru and Panchala flourished in the north, while regions like Koshala and Videha also prospered.

The Kurus: The Kurus, who expanded east to Kurukshetra (modern Delhi), allied with the Panchalas and dominated the region, with Hastinapur as their capital. They are best known for the **Battle of Bharat (950 BCE)** between the Kauravas and Pandavas, central to the Mahabharata, which nearly wiped out the Kuru clan. **Parikshit and Janamejaya** were key Kuru kings. Excavations at Hastinapur show early town life, though not fully matching Mahabharata descriptions.

The Panchalas: The Panchalas, formed by the union of the Turvashas and Krivis, occupied the middle doab (modern Bareilly, Badaun, and Farukhabad). Known for philosopher kings like Pravahana Jaivali, they were important in later Vedic texts for their contributions to Brahmanical thought.

Koshala: Located in eastern Uttar Pradesh, Koshala is associated with the story of Ram, though not mentioned in later Vedic texts.

Videha: Janaka, the famous king of Videha (Bihar) and capital Mithila, hosted a philosophical debate in the Brihadaranyaka Upanishad. He offered a reward for the wisest Brahmanas, leading to a contest where Yagyavalkya, challenged by Gargi Vachaknavi, responded fiercely to her probing questions on metaphysical topics.

Role of Tribal Chiefs

Tribal chiefs, initially protectors of people and cattle, evolved into protectors of **territory (rashtra)** with the rise of Janapadas. The term *kshatriya* replaced *raja/rajan*, reflecting their increased power and control over resources. Voluntary offerings like **bali** and **bhaga** became obligatory, though not fully taxed.

Legitimizing Kingship

The concept of kingship's origin emerged in the *Aitareya Brahmana*, with the gods appointing Indra after their defeat by demons. Texts like the *Shatapatha Brahmana* linked kings to the divine through rituals like *rajasuya* and *vajapeya*.

Titles and Hereditary Kingship

Kings were called different titles based on regions, such as ***raja***, ***samrat***, ***svarat***, and ***ekraat***. Hereditary kingship emerged, typically passing to the eldest son, though succession was not always smooth, as seen in the Mahabharata.

Consecratory Rituals

Kings performed lavish rituals like ***rajasuya***, ***ashvamedha***, and ***vajapeya*** to legitimize their authority. Despite the rise of hereditary kingship, kings were still answerable to their clans, and the office was typically restricted to the *kshatriya* lineage.

Rajasuya Sacrifice

The *Rajasuya* sacrifice was a ceremony to establish a king's sovereignty, often following a military victory. It included agrarian fertility rites and a cattle raid where the king would raid his kinsmen's cattle. The king also made offerings to his loyal functionaries, known as ***ratnins***, at the end of the ritual.

Ashvamedha Sacrifice

The *Ashvamedha* sacrifice involved releasing a royal horse to wander for a year. If the horse was not captured or killed by an enemy, it was sacrificed, and the king was declared the supreme ruler over the territory it traversed. The ceremony also featured fertility rites, with the presence of the chief queen thought to ensure prosperity for the king.

Vajapeya Sacrifice

The *Vajapeya* sacrifice was a chariot race where the royal chariot had to win against those of the king's kinsmen.

Administrative System and Functionaries

The king's administration expanded, assisted by functionaries like the ***purohita*** (priest), ***senani*** (military leader), and ***gramani*** (village

head). These functionaries, known as *ratnins* (jewels), helped the king manage the growing territories.

List of Ratnins	
1. brahmana (purohita, he headed the list)	9. sangrahitri (head of treasury)
2. rajanya (nobles)	10. bhagadhugha (literally, milker of shares; collector of king's share of produce)
3. mahishi (chief queen)	11. akshavapa (literally, thrower of dice; a functionary concerned with maintenance of accounts)
4. parvrikta (discarded queen)	12. gavikartana (chief huntsman)
5. senani (commander of the army)	13. takshan (carpenter)
6. suta (charioteer/bard)	14. rathakara (chariot maker)
7. gramani (village headman)	15. palagala (courier)
8. kshattri (royal chamberlain)	16. sthapati (judge/local chief)

Warriors and Priests

The kshatriya class, initially warrior elites, became responsible for protecting territories. The priestly class (Brahmanas) gained greater importance, particularly through sacrificial rituals that legitimized the king's authority. These rituals and the priests' influence grew, as they became integral to maintaining social and political order.

Justice and Legal System

The legal system was informal, with custom as law. Disputes were settled by the chief or king, often with assistance from priests and elders. Punishments, like compensation through cattle (wergild), were common, and trial by ordeal was practiced. Higher varnas faced lighter punishment.

In sum, the later Vedic period saw a significant shift towards territorial polities, with emerging monarchies, evolving administrative structures, and a growing importance of priests and warriors.

Society

Society became more complex with a firm four-fold varna system: Brahmanas (priests), Kshatriyas (warriors), Vaishyas (producers), and Shudras (menial workers). Brahmanas and Kshatriyas dominated, while Vaishyas paid tribute, and Shudras were seen as lower-status workers.

Varna System

- **Emergence of Jati (Caste)**

New groups, like forest people and artisans, were classified as separate castes (jati), with Brahmanas considered the purest and Shudras the least pure. The term "caste" was introduced by Portuguese traders.

- **Purity and Rituals**

The *Purusha-sukta* hymn described the varnas as divine, with Brahmanas from the mouth, Kshatriyas from the arms, Vaishyas from the thighs, and Shudras from the feet, symbolizing inequality.

- **Social Hierarchy**

Brahmanas and Kshatriyas were dominant, with Vaishyas as tribute-payers and Shudras serving others. The upper varnas were "twice-born" and entitled to sacred rites, unlike Shudras.

- **Subjugation and Inequality**

Brahmanas and Kshatriyas subjugated lower varnas through taxes and rituals. The varna system was based on birth and purity, with strict rules on marriage and social interactions.

- **Features of Varna System**

The system was tied to dharma and maintained social order, though it was not fully developed. Non-Vedic tribes interacted with the system, and in later periods, non-Kshatriyas like the Nandas and Mauryas rose to power.

- **Other Social Groups**

- **Dasas:** Originally referring to indigenous people in the Rigvedic period, the term *dasa* evolved to describe those enslaved or subordinated, with slaves often regarded as gifts in rituals.
- **Chandalas:** Tasked with disposing of the dead, Chandalas were considered low-status, with the ***Chandogya Upanishad*** suggesting that their birth resulted from bad actions in previous lives.
- **Mlechchhas:** A term for non-Aryan groups, such as forest dwellers and tribals, who did not follow Aryan customs. They were viewed as **"impure barbarians"** and considered outsiders to the caste system. Regions like Magadha, Anga, and Vanga, and tribes like Satvant, Andhra, and Nishadha were labeled as mlechchha lands.

Family and Household

The patriarchal family structure became prominent, with the ***grihapati*** (**householder**) holding significant authority. The relationships within the family were hierarchical, and the father had control over inheritance. The right of primogeniture was emphasized in royal families, and male ancestors were worshipped. Only married men with legitimate wives could perform sacrifices as *yajamana*.

Women's Role and Status

In the Later Vedic period, while some texts praise women, their overall status declined. The Shatapatha Brahmana views a wife as half of her husband, completing him, while the Brihadaranyaka Upanishad suggests rituals for obtaining a learned daughter. Women were occasionally involved in philosophical debates or coronation rituals but generally held a subordinate position. The Aitareya Brahmana describes daughters as a source of misery, and the Atharva Veda contains charms to change a female fetus into a male.

Women were often treated as commodities, exchanged in marriage to secure alliances. They were primarily defined by their roles as wives and mothers, with few personal rights. They were excluded from rituals like the sacred thread ceremony and could not study the Vedas or perform Vedic sacrifices. Their political rights were also restricted, and they could not attend assemblies. In many ways, women's status became akin to that of Shudras, with their subjugation increasing as the state emerged.

Vedic Women	Details
Apala (in Rigveda)	took care of her father's fields.
Vishpala, Mudgalini, Vadhramati	were some women warriors; Vishpala even lost a leg in battle.
Gargi, Maitreyi	participated in philosophical debates.

Other terms referring to women workers include

Vedic Terms	Description
siri, vayitri	female weaver
Peshaskari	female embroiderer
Rajayitri	female dyer
Bidalakari	female splitter of bamboo
Upalaprakshini	woman corn grinder

Marriage

Later Vedic texts mention various forms of marriage, including marriage by choice and by capture. Men were allowed multiple wives, but women were typically permitted only one husband. Marriage was seen as a woman joining not only a man but also his family. The Surya-sukta from the Rigveda portrays the bride as both an asset and a potential threat.

The Shatapatha Brahmana defines a good woman as one who pleases her husband, bears male children, and remains obedient. The texts also mention the practice of dowry, bride price, and levirate marriage (niyoga). Widows were sometimes expected to perform self-immolation, which later became linked to the practice of sati.

Gotra (Clan Affiliation):

The concept of gotra, referring to clan affiliation, emerged during the later Vedic period. The term "gotra" originally meant a cow-pen or the place where a clan's cattle were kept, symbolizing descent from a common ancestor or clan. Marriages within the same gotra were prohibited, establishing the practice of gotra exogamy.

Ashramas (Stages of Life):

The later Vedic texts mention three primary ashramas or life stages: Brahmacharya (student), Grihastha (householder), and Vanaprastha (partially retired). The fourth stage, Sanyasa (renunciation), was not yet fully established. The ascetic lifestyle existed but was not widespread.

A brahmachari, or male student, was expected to beg from his mother or the teacher's wife. The Grihastha life, or householder phase, was most commonly followed by all four varnas. In the post-Vedic period, many sanyasis or ascetics protested against Vedic socio-religious norms.

Education and Sciences:

Later Vedic texts mention a wide range of subjects, including the Vedas, itihasa (epic history), puranas (legends), brahma vidya (spiritual knowledge), rashi (mathematics), nidhi (chronology), vakovakya (dialectics), ekayana (ethics), astronomy, and military science. However, only religious and philosophical texts have survived.

Education emphasized the teacher-student relationship and was transmitted orally. The Upanayana ceremony marked the initiation of boys into Brahmacharya. Education was largely restricted to males from elite classes. A Rigveda hymn humorously compares students' repetition of lessons to frogs croaking.

Food, Clothing, and Leisure:

The later Vedic texts mention various food items, including **odana (rice or grain dish)**, **apupa (cake)**, **yavagu (barley gruel)**, and **karambha (porridge)**. Meat was consumed on ceremonial occasions and for guests, while intoxicating drinks like **sura and madhu (mead)** were also enjoyed. Clothing was made from cotton and wool, with turbans and leather sandals also mentioned. Ornaments such as **nishka (necklace)** and **prakasha (metal mirror)** were worn.

Popular leisure activities included horse racing, chariot racing, dancing, music, gambling, and dice games. Musical instruments included the **vina (lute)**, **vana (flute)**, drums, conches, and a harp or lyre with 100 strings. The Samaveda chanting demonstrated advanced knowledge of sound. Entertainers, such as **shailusha (dancers/actors)** and **vansha nartin (pole dancers/acrobat)**, were part of the cultural scene.

Religion

Religion in the Later Vedic phase became more complex, with two primary traditions emerging: Vedic and Non-Vedic (or folk) traditions.

Vedic Religious Tradition

This tradition is chiefly documented in the Sama and Yajur Vedas, along with the Brahmanas. It was primarily sacrificial, influenced by Brahmanical practices, and accompanied by rituals and mantras.

- **Philosophy and Beliefs:** The Later Vedic texts introduced various creation beliefs, such as those in the Purusha-sukta of the Rigveda, which presents abstract ideas about creation. Some hymns also address Vishvadevas (all gods), and various gods are seen as manifestations of a single divine being.
- **Changing Vedic Gods:** Over time, gods like Agni, Indra, and Varuna lost their earlier prominence, and new gods emerged, such

as **Prajapati (the creator), Vishnu (the protector), and Rudra (the destroyer)**. Prajapati, associated with sacrifice, became the supreme deity in the later Vedic pantheon. Pushan, once a protector of cattle, became associated with the Shudras.

- **Objective and Methods of Worship:** The purpose of worship remained material, with sacrifices growing in importance. Rituals and sacrifices, particularly Yajnas, were viewed as essential for sustaining the world. Scholars argue that orthopraxy (ritual practice) began to outweigh orthodoxy (doctrinal belief).
- **Yajnas (Sacrifices):** Sacrifices, both private and public, became more elaborate. Agnihotra, a domestic ritual, was performed daily, while public sacrifices like the Rajasuya and Ashvamedha involved the whole community. The sacrificial rituals became costly and intricate, with animal sacrifices becoming widespread. The yajamana (performer of the sacrifice) had to undergo diksha (consecration) before conducting the rituals.
- **Priesthood:** With the increasing complexity of rituals, a specialized priesthood emerged, dominated by Brahmanas. These priests not only performed sacrifices but also monopolized priestly knowledge. They demanded significant sacrificial fees, including cows, horses, gold, and land.

Non-Vedic or Folk Tradition

The Non-Vedic tradition, as described in the Atharvaveda, differed from Vedic rituals by focusing on domestic magic, spells, and charms for prosperity, health, and protection. Gods and spirits were invoked for everyday concerns, like crop protection or safe childbirth, blending folk beliefs with Brahmanical practices.

Religious Reform and Asceticism

By the end of the Vedic period, dissatisfaction with priestly authority led to the rise of asceticism and the Upanishadic philosophy in regions like Panchala and Videha. The Upanishads rejected material rituals in favor of spiritual knowledge, emphasizing the unity of the soul (atman) with the supreme being (Brahman), which promoted stability and helped strengthen states.

Conclusion

The Rigvedic society was dynamic, with changes from 1500-1000 BCE leading to a more complex socio-economic and political structure in the Later Vedic phase. Compared to the early Vedic period, the later phase saw transitions from a nomadic pastoral economy to settled agriculture, from an egalitarian society to a hierarchical one, and from the chalcolithic to the iron age. The shift from tribal to territorial states, and the emergence of janapadas, marked this period. Although agricultural limitations hindered urban growth, some communities in North India were on the brink of urbanization by the end of the Later Vedic period.